THE REFINERY
A BioNanomics program
Electric Works, Fort Wayne, Ind.

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
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High school robots in Halloween costumes compete at Wayne High School Oct. 31 as Monster Match pairs a FIRST Robotics Competition with a college and career fair

Co-hosted by The REFINERY, Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, Region 8 Education Service Center and NEI TechFest. Free and open to the public; matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m., college and career fair 10 a.m. to 2 p.m.

FORT WAYNE, Ind. – On Saturday, Oct. 31, high school robotics teams bring the robots they designed and built this year to Wayne High School for Monster Match, a Halloween-themed FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event. Seventeen teams are registered and the field stays open until it reaches 32.

The day combines a robotics competition, a college and career fair and a costume contest with categories for individuals, teams and robots. To be eligible in the robot category, a robot has to play its matches in costume. Admission is free. Matches run from 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.

Every January, FIRST Robotics Competition releases a new game to more than 3,700 high school teams worldwide at the same moment, and teams have about two months to design and build a machine to play it before competitions begin in March. This year's game, REBUILT, asked robots to collect foam balls, shoot them into a goal on a 54-foot field and climb a tower in the final seconds of each match.

The robots can weigh up to 115 pounds. Students do the work: they design in CAD, machine the metal parts, wire the electronics, write the code and drive in matches where alliances of three robots play against three.

Teams also run like small companies, raising their own money, recruiting sponsors and managing their own budgets. Participants are eligible for more than $80 million in college scholarships.

Offseason events like Monster Match give teams one more chance to compete with this year's robots and a chance to train newer members before the next game is released on Jan. 9. Because it falls on Halloween, Monster Match adds costume contests, trick-or-treating and a robot photo booth.

In the same building, colleges, employers and trade and technical schools host a college and career fair from 10 a.m. to 2 p.m., putting students in front of the regional employers who need the skills they use to build a robot. Families can trick-or-treat through the exhibitor booths while the fair is open and watch matches throughout the day.

Monster Match is co-hosted by The REFINERY; Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, a student organization at Purdue University Fort Wayne; Region 8 Education Service Center, the cooperative of public, private and parochial schools serving 15 Northeast Indiana counties; and NEI TechFest, the Northeast Indiana Tech Coalition's annual event connecting high school students with the region's technology employers. Sponsors include Daniels Associates, Inc.; Resultant; the City of Fort Wayne; Indiana Tech; and Huntington University.

About The REFINERY

The REFINERY is Northeast Indiana's first robotics-only facility, a nonprofit makerspace at Electric Works operated by BioNanomics, a nonprofit. It gives FIRST Robotics Competition and FIRST Tech Challenge teams across a 12-county region the shop space, fabrication equipment, training and mentorship that many of them could not afford on their own. refineryrobotics.org

WHAT	Monster Match, a FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event, college and career fair and costume contest
WHEN	Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026. Matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m. College and career fair and trick-or-treating 10 a.m. to 2 p.m.
WHERE	Wayne High School, 9100 Winchester Road, Fort Wayne, IN 46819
ADMISSION	Free and open to the public
TEAM REGISTRATION	Free, teamconvene.org/event/the-refinery/monster-match
FOR MEDIA	Students and mentors are available for interviews before the event, and media are welcome at Wayne High School throughout the day on Oct. 31. Logos, video and the press kit: https://refineryrobotics.org/press/. Photos on request from the media contact. Official FIRST photography: firstinspires.org/about/press-room/first-photos (credit: Photo courtesy FIRST).

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Media contact: Cameron Elder, Creative Director, The REFINERY
celder@bionanomics.com
260-450-9038